A FIELD GUIDE FROM PERSEVERANT DIGITAL · FOR SENIOR LIVING

How to Fill Move-Ins Without Depending on Referral-Site Fees

A plan to bring more families to you directly: know what each move-in costs by source, answer in minutes, earn more tours and stay close to families who need months to decide.

THE SHORT ANSWER · 59 WORDS REVIEWED OCTOBER 15, 2026

Track cost per move-in by source, then shift effort toward the sources you control: a Google and AI presence that names you for the right care level and town, an offer families want, a human reply within minutes, and a patient follow-up plan for families who need months to decide. Keep referral sites only where the numbers earn it.

You probably know the feeling. A referral-site lead comes in, and three other communities called the same family before you did. The fee comes due when they move in, sometimes after your own team did most of the work. Meanwhile your website inquiries sit in a shared inbox until morning.

The person on the other end is often an adult child. She is researching at night, after work, for a parent who just had a fall or a hard hospital stay. She wants costs, care levels and a real person. If you don't answer quickly, someone else will.

This guide is a plan for fixing that. Most of it you can start this week.

Where are your move-ins coming from, and what does each one cost?

Start with the numbers. Many communities know their monthly referral-site bill but not the cost per move-in for each source.

Senior Housing News reported on one operator that received 465 referral-site leads in 2024, which produced 12 move-ins. The operator cancelled those contracts. Fill this in for the last 12 months. Pull move-ins from your CRM, not from memory.

Source	Spend or fees	Inquiries	Tours held	Move-ins	Cost per move-in
Referral sites					
Google Ads					
Google Business Profile and organic search					
Your website forms and calls					
Hospital, physician and care manager referrals					
Events and family education nights					

Cost per move-in = (spend + fees + staff time you can fairly assign) ÷ move-ins from that source.

Example numbers, not benchmarks: if a source cost $18,000 in fees and produced 4 move-ins, that is $4,500 per move-in. If your own search and website cost $9,000 and produced 6, that is $1,500.

One warning: long sales cycles overwrite the first source. Check that your CRM keeps the original source when a later touch is logged.

Will Google and AI assistants name you when a family asks?

Many families now ask Google and AI assistants questions they once asked a senior placement service. Google says AI Mode passed 1 billion monthly users (Alphabet, July 22, 2026). BrightLocal's 2026 survey found use of AI tools for local recommendations rose from 6% to 45% (BrightLocal, February 11, 2026).

Those answers can quote referral sites, which have plain pages on care levels and costs. Yours can be quoted too if they say plainly what you do, for whom, where and at what cost. We call this Search Essence Optimization: families search to understand you, not just to find you, so your pages should meet them there.

- [ ] Ask ChatGPT and Google “best memory care near [town]” and “assisted living vs. home care for my dad.” Note who is named and which pages are cited.
- [ ] Correct your care levels, pricing language and contact details on every referral site and directory that shows up.
- [ ] Give each care level its own page: independent living, assisted living, memory care, respite. Lead with a two-sentence answer of who it is for.
- [ ] Publish honest starting cost ranges, or explain exactly what changes the price. Remove old pricing anywhere you find it.
- [ ] Set your Google Business Profile category precisely and list tour hours that include evenings or weekends, when adult children can visit.
- [ ] Ask adult children for reviews about a month after move-in. Reply in your own words and never mention a resident’s health or care.
- [ ] Check that your site doesn’t block AI search crawlers. Sites that opt out of OpenAI’s search crawler won’t appear in ChatGPT search answers (OpenAI crawler documentation).

BrightLocal also found 47% of people won’t use a local business with fewer than 20 reviews. Never buy, filter or fake reviews; the FTC’s 2024 rule bans it (Morgan Lewis, August 26, 2024).

What offer gets a family to raise a hand?

A tour is the goal, but it is a big step for a family that is still deciding whether Mom needs help. Offer something smaller first, phrased as their question.

Offer	Fits	Why it works
Tour and lunch	Independent and assisted living	Lets the parent picture daily life
Family education night	All care levels	Meets families months before they’re ready
“What does care cost here?” call	All	Answers the question they’re afraid to ask
In-home care assessment	Home care	Their version of a tour

Family education nights answer real questions: how to pay for care, how to tell when a parent needs help, how to talk about moving. Host them on site so the

event doubles as a tour, and ask discharge planners and care managers to share the invitation.

Ask about timing and type of care on your forms, not a parent's medical history. Save health details for the conversation.

Rules that shape your ads (not legal advice). Senior housing ads can fall under Meta's housing Special Ad Category. Age targeting is fixed at 18–65+, gender and ZIP targeting are restricted and lookalike audiences are unavailable (Meta Marketing API documentation). Your message has to do the targeting: write to the adult child. Claims that a community is 55+ depend on the Housing for Older Persons Act exemption, so confirm you qualify before saying it (NAHB, November 30, 2021).

How fast do you need to answer an inquiry?

Within minutes, by a person, every day. It is the cheapest fix in this plan and the one most often missed.

In mystery shops of senior living communities, 53% of web inquiries got no response within two hours and 13% never got one. Inquiry-to-tour conversion averaged 22% (Bild & Co. via Senior Housing News, February 12, 2024). Across industries, firms that contacted web leads within an hour were nearly seven times as likely to qualify them as firms that waited longer (Harvard Business Review, March 2011).

One unanswered call isn't the end. Aline, a senior living CRM vendor, reported that web leads often need three to four touches before they respond (Aline, March 4, 2025).

First hour

- [ ] Inquiries route to a named person's phone, with a backup for evenings and weekends.
- [ ] Call within five minutes. If no answer, send a short text (with consent) and an email from that person.
- [ ] Offer two specific tour times, including one outside business hours.

First week

- [ ] Day 1: second call at a different time of day.
- [ ] Day 2: email answering the question they asked, with a cost range.
- [ ] Day 4: third call, plus a note to the adult child if a parent inquired, or the reverse.

- [ ] Day 7: invite them to the next family education night.

Texting rules (not legal advice). Prior express written consent is still required for autodialed or prerecorded marketing calls and texts. Since April 11, 2025, people can revoke consent by any reasonable means, such as replying STOP, and opt-outs must be honored within 10 business days (Kelley Drye; Burr & Forman).

How do you stay close to families who aren't ready yet?

Many families aren't ready when they first call, so plan for months. Aline reported a move-in takes about 28 sales activities (March 4, 2025). That is a cadence, not a burst.

Month	Touch	Who sends it
1	Personal check-in call; invite to an event	Sales director
2	Guide to paying for care (general information)	Email
4	"Has anything changed?" call	Sales director
6	Family education night invitation	Email and call
8	Seasonal note before the holidays, when families notice changes	Personal email
10	Respite stay or tour-and-lunch offer	Call
12	Check in, or ask if they'd like to stop hearing from you	Sales director

Write to the adult child and the parent separately when you can. Each email needs a working unsubscribe and a postal address (FTC CAN-SPAM guide).

What changes for home care agencies?

Your win is a client start, not a move-in. Three things change.

First, list only the areas you can staff. Activated Insights reported 63.3% of home care providers turned down cases in 2023 because they couldn't staff them, with caregiver turnover at 79.2% (via Home Health Care News, August 2024). A client you can't serve costs you the lead and often a review. Track "declined, no staff" as its own stage.

Second, your “tour” is the in-home assessment. Measure cost per assessment held and cost per client start by source.

Third, privacy. If you are a HIPAA covered entity (confirm with counsel), tracking on scheduling pages or other pages that carry protected health information is still covered, and vendors handling it need a business associate agreement (HHS OCR guidance). Whether or not HIPAA applies, keep care needs and diagnoses out of ad platforms, analytics and texts. Not legal advice.

Where do most owners get stuck?

> **Clean source data.** Keeping the first source intact across 28 activities, and crediting referral sites fairly, takes deliberate CRM setup. Many CRMs don’t do it by default.

> **Evening and weekend coverage.** Everyone agrees on a five-minute reply. Many teams can’t staff it at 9 p.m. on a Sunday without a routing plan and a human backup.

> **Pages good enough to be quoted.** Building care-level and cost pages that Google and AI assistants cite ahead of referral sites is slow, steady work that rarely fits around running a building.

If one of these sounds familiar, book a 25-minute exploration call through the short form at the end of this guide. We’ll look at your numbers with you.

Sources

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Want a second set of eyes on your plan?

Book a free 25-minute exploration call. We will look at your numbers with you, name the first fixes in order, and tell you honestly if we are not the right fit.

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